

greens.” Once cut, you might be able to persuade the remaining stumps to produce a second crop: with a sharp knife, make a cross-cut pattern on the stalk and water as normal. Alternatively, wait for your cabbages to develop dense hearts, and then cut the head from the roots with a sharp knife. Use spring and summer types as soon as possible after harvesting, since they don’t keep well.

Harvest fall and winter cabbages as needed. Winter cabbages are frost-hardy and slow to bolt—they can be left in the ground over winter, so there is no rush to harvest them. As with spring and summer cabbages, cut the heads from the roots with a sharp knife, or dig the entire cabbage up. To reduce the risk of diseases persisting in the soil, dig up all remaining roots shortly after harvesting.

STORING

Fall and winter cabbages can be stored for months if they are harvested before the first frosts, but ensure that they are cut with at least a 6 in (15 cm) stem. Hang them in net bags in a cool dark place, or lay them on wooden slats and cover them with straw or newspaper, to protect them if the weather turns cold.

PESTS

You may find your cabbages under threat from a range of pests, and may have to use more than one different measure during the crop’s growth. When seedlings are young or first planted out, use a collar to prevent cabbage root flies from laying eggs next to the vulnerable plants. You can make your own using a small square of cardboard or carpet underlay.

Consider using a cloche or the cut off top of a plastic bottle for protection against other pests such as cabbage caterpillars and mealy cabbage aphids, although these may also be a problem at later stages of growth. Use netting to keep birds and cabbage white butterflies away. Construct a wooden or wire frame over your plants and attach the netting to it.



Cabbage white butterfly caterpillars will swarm on a cabbage, stripping its leaves. Pick the caterpillars off by hand. If necessary, spray with an insecticide.